

For brokers, consultants and developers
closing deals in Dubai and the wider UAE.
Issued August 2026.

The Deal-Rescue Playbook

Seven ways a Dubai deal dies after the price is agreed,
and the structure that closes each one.

No transfer, no commission.



Ten minutes to read. One live file to use it on.

Every entry is built the same way: what the file looks like, the number behind it, why the bank cannot move, what it costs you, and the move that closes it. The last line of each is a question worth asking before the deal reaches that point rather than after.

Nothing here is about a bad property. Every one of the seven is a structure problem sitting on an asset that was fine.

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ON THE NUMBERS

Sources are numbered at the foot of each page. Where a figure is bank policy rather than regulation, it says so, because those are the ones worth a second call.

Deals die at the table, not at the viewing.

The commission pool in Dubai is at a record. The number of people dividing it is at a record too, and the two are not moving at the same rate. What decides which side of that line an agent sits on is rarely the property. It is whether the financing behind it holds together in the last three weeks.

27,000

Brokers registered in Dubai in 2025, against about 4,500 in 2019

~1 in 5

Of them close anything at all in a year

42,181

Deals facilitated by 29,577 brokers in H1 2025

AED 3.23bn

Commissions recorded across those deals

And one rule change moved the goalposts

Until the start of 2025 UAE banks routinely folded the transaction costs into the mortgage. From 1 February 2025 they stopped. The four per cent Dubai Land Department transfer fee and the two per cent agency commission are no longer financed and have to be paid in cash at the point of transfer.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FEE

Read the second half of that sentence again, because it is your money in it. The two per cent that is no longer financed is the commission. It has moved out of the bank's column and into the client's cash column, where it now competes directly with the deposit for the same limited pile of dirhams. When a buyer is short at the table, the pressure to renegotiate your fee comes from exactly this arithmetic.

1. The National (2025), broker registration and completion rates. 2. Dubai Media Office / DLD, H1 2025 broker activity.
3. Khaleej Times and The National (January 2025), effective 1 February 2025.

The valuation gap

THE FILE

The price is agreed and the deposit is paid. The bank's panel valuer comes back under the agreed figure, and the bank advances against the lower of the two.

-10%

Shortfalls of around ten per cent are ordinary rather than exceptional. On an AED 4m purchase that is AED 400,000 in cash that nobody budgeted for.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

The valuation is commissioned by the bank from its own panel, and it is a ceiling rather than an opening position. The buyer sees the number only after it lands, by which point the MoU is already running.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

Renegotiating down to the valuation takes the commission with the price and resets the seller's expectations. In a rising market the seller often prefers to relist, and then the file is gone rather than reduced.

THE MOVE

Capital raised against a UAE property the buyer or a family member already owns, sized against that asset's valuation rather than against the buyer's payslip, covers the gap. The purchase completes at the agreed price, and the commission is paid on the agreed price.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

Which bank is on the file, and has anyone seen a recent valuation on this building rather than on this unit?

1. EGSB valuation practice; CBUAE mortgage regulations.

The non-resident LTV wall

THE FILE

A strong foreign buyer with money offshore and no UAE residency. The offer letter comes back needing far more down than the buyer had planned for, and the deposit is already with the agency.

60-65%

Non-residents are typically advanced 60 to 65 per cent of valuation, against up to 80 per cent for residents. They arrive needing 35 to 40 per cent in cash.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

The limit is set by residency, not by the asset. The same property behind a resident buyer carries more.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

The buyers who look strongest on paper are the ones who stall here, and they stall late, after the MoU is signed and the seller is counting on the date.

THE MOVE

Co-financing secured on the property underwrites the asset rather than the passport. Worth knowing first: the non-resident ceiling is bank policy rather than a Central Bank rule, which is why it differs between banks. A second bank is worth a call before the file is abandoned.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

Is the buyer resident, and how much of their cash is actually landed in the UAE rather than committed abroad?

1. CBUAE mortgage regulations; UAE bank published lending policies.

The off-plan financing gap

THE FILE

Off-plan, and the developer's payment plan wants 20 to 30 per cent across booking and the first instalments. The buyer assumed a mortgage would carry that part.

50-60%

No mortgage until construction reaches roughly 50 to 60 per cent complete. The first half of the payment plan sits with the buyer.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

A bank prices completion risk, and an unbuilt unit is not security it will take. Since mid 2026 a small number of developer and bank programmes reach earlier into construction, but only on their own developer lists and only once half the plan is paid. For a mid-market developer there is usually no partnership at all.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

The buyer self-funds the middle of the plan or does not buy. Either way the file goes quiet for a year, and the reservation is the only thing you were paid on.

THE MOVE

Short-term co-financing against an existing asset bridges the construction-stage instalments until bank financing becomes available.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

Which developer, and is there a named bank partnership on this specific project rather than on the developer's flagship one?

1. UAE bank off-plan mortgage policies. 2. NEMAX market note on earlier off-plan bank financing, verified August 2026.

The handover cash shortfall

THE FILE

Handover is called, the final instalment falls due, and the buyer's money is tied up in another property that has not sold yet. Without the balance there is no NOC and no transfer.

25-40%

On default a developer can retain up to 25 per cent of the price where the project is less than 60 per cent complete, and as much as 40 per cent above that.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

Retention is set by law and does not depend on why the buyer is short. The developer's remedy runs on its own timetable, through grace period, late charges and a notice served through the DLD.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

No transfer, no commission, and a client who has lost a quarter of everything they paid. That client does not come back with the next purchase.

THE MOVE

A bridge to handover secured on the asset. The balance is covered, the unit is handed over, and the other property sells at its own pace rather than at auction speed.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

When is handover expected to be called, and where exactly is the final payment coming from?

1. Article 11 of Law No. 13 of 2008, as amended by Law No. 19 of 2017; DLD explanatory notes.

The DBR ceiling

THE FILE

A buyer who owns property outright, runs a business, and declares a modest salary. On paper they are the safest client you have. The bank declines them.

50%

The Central Bank caps the debt burden ratio at 50 per cent of monthly income, and unused credit-card limits count against it.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

DBR is a regulatory limit measured on the person. A strong property cannot argue with it, because it is not the thing being measured.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

The asset-rich buyers are the ones with the money and the ones the bank refuses. You lose the deal and the referral chain behind it.

THE MOVE

Asset-based underwriting starts from the other end and asks what the property carries, not what the payslip says. The same file can be dead at one desk and alive at another because the question is different.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

What is the buyer's declared income, and how many card limits are open in their name that they never use?

1. CBUAE Rulebook, mortgage lending standards.

The speed problem

THE FILE

The MoU is signed and running. Underwriting is still asking for documents, and the seller has stopped answering about an extension.

30 vs 4-6

The MoU, signed as RERA Form F, typically runs about 30 days. Underwriting a buyer with foreign or self-employed income runs four to six weeks. The two numbers do not fit inside each other.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

The mismatch is structural rather than a matter of one bank being slow. Cross-border compliance takes the time it takes, and the Form F clock was never set to accommodate it.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

When the MoU lapses the seller is free. Sometimes there is an extension. Often there is a cash buyer who has been waiting politely for exactly this moment.

THE MOVE

Capital in place for transfer day so a financed buyer can complete on a cash buyer's timetable, with a bank refinancing afterwards at its own pace. NEMAX targets around 30 days from application to funds in place, which is the lower end of the market rather than a different order of speed.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

What date is on the Form F, and is the buyer's income foreign or self-employed?

1. Dubai Media Office / DLD; Khaleej Times, mortgage underwriting timelines.

The business-liquidity block

THE FILE

The client owns real estate and runs a company, and the capital is needed for the business rather than for the purchase. The bank looks at the trading company and stops there.

USD 250bn

The SME funding gap across the GCC is estimated at roughly USD 250bn.

WHY THE BANK CANNOT MOVE

Business credit is underwritten on the trading entity, not on the property standing behind it. The asset is visible on the balance sheet and invisible to the decision.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

The client sells the asset to raise the cash. You get one transaction and lose the owner, when the alternative kept both.

THE MOVE

Capital raised against the property turns a held asset into short-term liquidity without a sale, structured through a dedicated SPV holding that one deal.

ASK BEFORE IT HAPPENS

Does the client actually need to sell, or do they need the money that the sale would produce?

1. IFC / World Bank SME finance estimates, GCC scope.

Three more that kill it late.

These do not appear until the financing question is already answered, which is what makes them expensive. All three are visible before the MoU is signed, if anyone looks.

The developer's NOC

Unpaid service charges or an open dispute, and the eNOC does not issue. No eNOC, no DLD transfer, and the appointment is cancelled against an MoU that is already running. The certificate itself costs AED 500 to 5,000 plus VAT and takes two to five working days.

[Ask for a service-charge statement on paper before the listing goes up.](#)

The seller's undischarged mortgage

Mortgage-on-mortgage transfers run up to around 60 days. The liability letter that starts the process can take 14 days to issue and is then valid for a short window. Miss it and it is reissued, and the clock restarts from a date nobody in the chain agreed to.

[Ask which bank holds the charge before the MoU is signed, not after.](#)

The cooling-off clawback

The roughly seven days buyers talk about on off-plan is a developer's contract term, not a RERA law. If the buyer cancels inside it, the developer claws the commission back after a signed SPA.

[Read the cancellation clause before you count the fee as earned.](#)

1. F&P Property; EGSH; DLD REST / Oqood. 2. Allsopp & Allsopp; 800homes. 3. Betterhomes. No statutory cooling-off period exists for off-plan.

Four moves. Three of them cost you money.

MOVE	WHAT IT DOES	WHAT IT COSTS YOU
Renegotiate down to the valuation	Sometimes works	The commission comes down with the price, and the seller's expectations reset. In a rising market the seller often relists instead
Find a different buyer	Realistic	Four to six weeks, against an MoU with about three left, and a deposit position that is rarely clean
Let the file go	Most common	All of it, and the client relationship with it
Close the gap with capital raised against the asset	Keeps the original price, the original buyer and the original commission	Nothing to the agent. The introducer fee is paid by NEMAX on top, after the deal completes

The arithmetic, on an ordinary file

ILLUSTRATIVE

Built from the ordinary case rather than from any particular file. Every deal is priced after valuation, legal review and due diligence. Not a commercial offer.

A villa is agreed at AED 4m. The buyer puts in 25 per cent and borrows the rest. The bank's panel valuer returns AED 3.6m, ten per cent under, and the bank advances against the lower figure. The buyer's own cash was already budgeted for the deposit and the transfer costs, which on this purchase run to roughly AED 300,000 before anything goes wrong. So the AED 400,000 gap does not land on a cushion. It lands on a buyer who has already written every cheque they planned to write.

Three of the four moves now cost the agent money. The fourth keeps the price where it was, and the commission is paid on AED 4m rather than on a renegotiated figure.

Five questions, ten minutes, most of this playbook avoided.

Every failure in this document is cheaper to find before the listing than after the MoU. These five are the ones that pay for themselves.

1 Get the service-charge position on paper.

Not the owner's recollection. An outstanding balance is what stops the eNOC, and it is the single most common reason a transfer date moves.

2 Ask whether there is a mortgage, and which bank holds it.

This decides whether the transfer is a two-week job or a two-month chain, and it decides it on day one.

3 Put in writing who pays the four per cent.

The law splits it between the parties. Practice puts it on the buyer. Silence puts it in an argument on transfer day.

4 Quote the all-in number in dirhams at the first meeting.

Roughly 6.5 to 8 per cent of the price all in on a cash purchase, more with a mortgage. Six lines, not one. A buyer who hears it early budgets for it. A buyer who hears it late renegotiates your fee.

5 Ask when the buyer's cash actually lands.

Not whether they have it. Funds committed to another sale, or sitting in an account abroad that takes three weeks to move, are the same as no funds on the day.

THEN RUN THE DEAL CHECK

Eight questions on the file itself, and it says whether the deal is worth structuring before you spend a month on it.

Keep the commission. Add an introducer fee.

If the asset is sound and the deal stalled on structure rather than on the property, it is worth sending. NEMAX reviews the structure and comes back in writing within 48 hours: what the property can carry, what it costs, and how long it takes.

From AED 1M

Deal size, secured on UAE real estate

Up to 70%

Of the property value

Around 30 days

From application to the capital being in place

How registration works

Joining happens once. One short form, and the referral link comes back in your name the same day, before anything is signed. Give that link to your client and the deal is recorded against you even while the agreement is still going back and forth. The NDA and the introducer agreement follow by email and are signed on screen. The login link arrives after that and opens your account, with everything you sent already waiting inside it.

The introducer fee is paid by NEMAX after the deal completes. What you agreed with your client is between the two of you and is not touched by any of it. If a client you introduced approaches NEMAX directly, you hear it from NEMAX first and the deal stays registered to you.

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nemax-finance.com/for-brokers

WHERE THIS DOES NOT FIT

There has to be a UAE property to work from. A buyer with no asset behind them, and no family member willing to put one forward, is outside this. Every file is priced after valuation, legal review and due diligence, and nothing in this document is a quote. Compliance obligations that sit with the brokerage, including goAML reporting and source-of-funds checks, are not affected by any of it and remain the brokerage's own.